

Moore, Russell and Early Wittgenstein — Answer-Writing Toolkit

Solved PYQs and Mains Practice

Solved Mains/PYQ workbook and transfer manual. All **16 directly owned verified PYQs through 2026** receive complete timed independent model answers. These are learner-practice answers, never official UPSC answer keys.

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Source and ownership discipline

- Exact wording and marks: [2018–2025 ledger](#) and [2026 ledger](#).
- Direct set: 2018 Q3(c), 2018 Q4(c), 2019 Q3(c), 2020 Q2(b), 2020 Q2(c), 2021 Q3(a), 2021 Q4(c), 2022 Q1(b), 2022 Q3(c), 2023 Q4(b), 2024 Q1(c), 2024 Q3(a), 2025 Q1(d), 2025 Q3(c), 2026 Q1(e), 2026 Q4(a).
- Cross-links do not inflate ownership: 2018 Q3(a) remains Empiricism-owned; Later Wittgenstein/private language remains later-owner material; verificationism and unified science remain Logical Positivism-owned. The hierarchy issue is primarily owned here.

Timed architecture

10 marks: thesis -> three exact moves -> canonical example -> qualification -> verdict
15 marks: reconstruction -> technical distinction -> objection/reply -> graded judgement
20 marks: complete architecture -> comparisons -> strongest seam -> defended ruling

High-value vocabulary

Moore: truisms; comparative certainty; knowing versus analysing; burden reversal; three proof conditions; act/object; diaphanous awareness; *esse est percipi*.

Russell: grammatical/logical form; atomic fact; negative fact; incomplete symbol; existence, uniqueness and predication; primary/secondary occurrence; acquaintance/description; logically proper name; construction; supreme maxim.

Early Wittgenstein: facts not things; state of affairs; logical space; pictorial/logical form; bipolarity; truth-function; N-operator; *sinnlos/unsinnig*; saying/showing; ladder; hierarchy.

1. 2018 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: How does Wittgenstein apply the distinction between 'saying' and 'showing' to point to a single way of apprehending the most decisive problems of philosophy? Is he justified? Give reasons for your answer.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger

Element	Requirement
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The saying/showing distinction gives Wittgenstein a *single* meta-philosophical method: the "most decisive problems" of philosophy are not solved but **dissolved**, because they are attempts to *say* what can only be *shown*. He is justified as diagnosis, though the method is self-undermining.

The distinction. To *say* is to assert a senseful factual proposition that pictures a contingent state of affairs (bipolar - capable of truth *and* falsity). What can only be *shown* includes the **logical form** language shares with the world, and the **ethical, aesthetic and mystical**.

The single way. Metaphysics, the self, the meaning of life and value all try to state what lies outside the picturable world; each is therefore *unsinnig* (nonsense), not false. The one correct method is, for every such problem, to exhibit that its sentences transgress the limits of sense - so the problem lapses. Logic, ethics and metaphysics are handled by one criterion.

Named text. Proposition 7: "Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent." The ladder (6.54): the Tractatus's propositions are nonsense to be climbed and then thrown away.

Is he justified? (reasons). - *For*: the distinction unifies logic and value under a single account of sense, deflates pseudo-problems, and influences later anti-metaphysical programmes without stating verificationism. - *Against*: the **self-referential paradox** - if the Tractatus is nonsense, how does it instruct? Russell objected that Wittgenstein "manages to say a good deal about what cannot be said." The **resolute** reading treats the sentences as therapeutic nonsense; the **standard** reading as illuminating nonsense that gestures at what shows itself. The underlying picture theory also faces the colour-exclusion problem.

Verdict. Justified as a diagnostic that relocates the decisive problems to the domain of showing; only partly justified as doctrine, since its self-application is paradoxical and is better read as *marking* the boundary than stating truth.

Measured model-answer words: 298

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It derives saying/showing from picture theory, distinguishes factual saying from logical manifestation, and evaluates the ladder without reducing value-discourse to falsehood.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

2. 2018 Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: How is Russell's theory of definite description related to his Logical Atomism? Discuss and give reasons for your answer.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The theory of definite descriptions is the **engine** of Logical Atomism: it shows how apparent referring expressions dissolve into quantificational structure, which licenses analysis down to genuine simples - the atoms.

Descriptions (the method). "The F is G" analyses as $(\exists x)[Fx \ \& \ (\forall y)(Fy \rightarrow y=x) \ \& \ Gx]$. "The present King of France is bald" is therefore **false, not meaningless**; "the F" is an **incomplete symbol** with no meaning in isolation that *disappears* on analysis.

Three links to atomism. 1. **Grammatical vs logical form.** Descriptions prove that surface grammar hides logical form; atomism is the thesis that this analysis *terminates* in atomic propositions picturing atomic facts. 2. **Incomplete symbols -> constructions.** The same device dissolves classes, numbers and material objects into **logical constructions**: "Wherever possible, substitute constructions out of known entities for inferences to unknown entities." What survives analysis are atoms (logically proper names) and universals. 3. **Ontological economy.** Descriptions banish Meinong's non-existent objects; atomism keeps only what analysis certifies. **Isomorphism** then pairs each atomic proposition with an atomic fact.

Named text. "On Denoting" (1905); the atoms are "logical atoms and not physical atoms" - the *last residue in analysis*, of which descriptions is the exemplar.

Objection/reply. Strawson (1950) charges that descriptions misdescribe ordinary use (presupposition, not assertion). Reply: even granting this about conversation, the *analytical* discovery - that meaning has hidden logical structure terminating in simples - is exactly what atomism needs.

Verdict. Descriptions supply the paradigm of analysis that atomism generalises; the two are one programme - method (descriptions) and its metaphysical terminus (atoms).

The relation is therefore enabling, not deductively conclusive.

Measured model-answer words: 259

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It connects descriptions to atomism through elimination of apparent constituents, uses existence-uniqueness-predication and qualifies the claimed route to simples.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

3. 2019 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Why is Moore's philosophy called common-sense realism?

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Moore's philosophy is "common-sense realism" because he holds that certain commonsense **truisms** about a **mind-independent** world are known with certainty, and that philosophy must answer to them rather than overturn them.

The "common-sense" half. In "A Defence of Common Sense" (1925) Moore lists **truisms** - I have a body, the earth existed for many years before my birth, there are other people - each "known to be true with certainty." Crucially, **knowing is not analysing**: we know a truism is true even when we cannot give its correct analysis (the paradox of analysis). Certainty attaches to the truism, not to any philosopher's theory of it.

The "realism" half. The world these truisms describe is **mind-independent**. This is reinforced by the **Refutation of Idealism** (act/object distinction defeats *esse est percipi*) and the **Proof of an External World** (1939): "Here is one hand... and here is another" is offered as a rigorous proof that external things exist.

Method / burden reversal. Philosophy defends common sense; when a sceptical or idealist argument conflicts with a truism, its premises are *less* certain than "here is one hand," so it is the argument that must be rejected.

Objection/reply. The sceptic charges question-begging. Reply: Moore reverses the **burden of proof** rather than refuting doubt head-on; Later *On Certainty* reframes the role of hinge-like certainties; this is comparison, not owner content.

Verdict. "Common-sense realism" is apt: it names Moore's **epistemology** (commonsense certainties) and his **ontology** (mind-independent realism) together, even if its anti-sceptical force remains contested.

Moore's realism is therefore methodological as well as ontological.

Measured model-answer words: 257

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It defines Moorean common-sense realism through truisms, knowing-versus-analysis and comparative certainty rather than merely repeating the hands gesture.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

4. 2020 Q2(b) · 15 marks

Question: Critically discuss the following statement by Moore: "If anyone tells us that to say 'Blue exists' is the same thing as to say that 'Both blue and consciousness exist', he makes a mistake and a self-contradictory mistake."

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The remark distils Moore's **Refutation of Idealism**: to identify "Blue exists" with "Both blue and consciousness exist" is to conflate the **object** of awareness with the **act** of awareness, and that identification is self-contradictory because the two propositions have different content.

Context. The target is Berkeley's *esse est percipi*. Idealism treats a sensation as an undifferentiated unity; Moore analyses every sensation into two elements - the **act** (consciousness, the *same* in the sensation of blue and of green) and the **object** (the blue, the green, which *differ*).

The quoted claim. "Blue exists" asserts the object; "blue and consciousness exist" asserts object *plus* act. To call these the *same* proposition is to smuggle consciousness into the very content of "blue." Since they plainly assert different things, the identification is a "self-contradictory mistake."

Diaphanous thesis. Consciousness is **transparent** - we look straight through it to the blue and overlook the act; that transparency is *why* the idealist fuses object with act and arrives at *esse est percipi*.

Result. Object $\neq$ act. This blocks the simple identity claim that the being of blue just is its being perceived; it does **not** by itself prove that blue persists unperceived. A further realist argument is required.

Critical assessment. - The **diaphanous** thesis is also Moore's soft spot: if awareness is never directly caught, the act/object distinction is *asserted* rather than *exhibited*. - **Limits:** the argument refutes *one* argument for idealism, not realism directly, and does **not** touch Hegel's Absolute Idealism. - The **sense-datum** legacy (object as a given item) later collapses under Sellars' "Myth of the Given."

Verdict. Moore's charge of self-contradiction lands squarely on the *identification*; the negative result is secure even though the positive sense-datum doctrine it inspired proved unstable.

Measured model-answer words: 283

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It reconstructs the blue-consciousness distinction, explains transparency and limits the conclusion to the failure of an identity-based idealist argument.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

5. 2020 Q2(c) · 15 marks

Question: "The reason that I call my doctrine logical atomism is because the atoms that I wish to arrive at as the sort of last residue in analysis are logical atoms and not physical atoms." Write a note on the nature of atomic facts according to Russell in the light of the above statement.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. For Russell, atomic facts are the simplest constituents of reality; they are **logical** atoms - the last residue of **analysis** - and emphatically **not physical** atoms.

The quotation. "The atoms that I wish to arrive at as the sort of last residue in analysis are logical atoms and not physical atoms." So "atomic" marks **logical simplicity and independence**, reached by analysing propositions, not microscopic size discovered by physics.

Nature of atomic facts. - An **atomic fact** is a simple particular having a quality or standing in a relation - e.g., "this is red." It is what corresponds to a true **atomic proposition** (a logically proper name, or names, plus a predicate). - **Atomic vs molecular:** molecular propositions ("p and q," "p or q") are **truth-functions** of atomic ones; the connectives name nothing - there is no "and"-fact in the world. - **Isomorphism:** a true atomic proposition shares the structure of its fact - names correspond to objects, and the *arrangement* of names to the *arrangement* of objects.

Logical, not physical (developed). The atoms are Russell's **sense-data and universals**, identified by acquaintance - an **epistemological** base. This contrasts with the *Tractatus*'s "objects," which are logical simples whose nature is left unspecified.

Objection/reply. The sense-datum base is empirically vulnerable (Sellars). Reply: whatever the ultimate simples turn out to be, the *logical* point stands - meaning and truth bottom out in atomic propositions picturing atomic facts.

Verdict. Atomic facts are the ontological correlates that analysis *requires*; the quoted sentence exists precisely to forbid mistaking them for tiny physical particles.

Measured model-answer words: 251

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It distinguishes logical from physical atoms, relates atomic facts to atomic propositions and qualifies the independence and final-analysis claims.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

6. 2021 Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: What are the main arguments put forward by Moore in his paper "A Defence of Common Sense" to prove that there are possible propositions about the world that are known to be true with certainty? Do you think Moore's arguments provide a sufficient response to objections presented by the sceptic against the possibility of knowledge? Give reasons in support of your answer.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.

Element	Requirement
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	340–400 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. In "A Defence of Common Sense," Moore argues that a class of commonsense **truisms** is known to be true with certainty; his answer to scepticism is a **burden-reversal** that is dialectically compelling but, against the radical sceptic, not demonstratively sufficient.

Moore's arguments in the 1925 paper. 1. **The list of truisms:** "I have a body," "the earth existed for years before my birth," and "there are other human beings" belong to classes of propositions that Moore says he knows *with certainty*. 2. **Known without complete analysis:** one may know such propositions while remaining unable to give their philosophically correct **analysis**. A demand for prior analysis therefore cannot cancel the knowledge already possessed. 3. **Comparative certainty:** if a philosophical premise entails that no one knows any external world proposition, Moore is more certain of the truism than of that premise. The rational response is to reject the less certain premise rather than abandon the better-known proposition. 4. **Consequences for scepticism:** a universal sceptic still speaks, remembers, addresses others and distinguishes appearance from reality. These commitments make sceptical consequences less credible than the common-sense framework they deny.

Later comparison only: the hand gesture in *Proof of an External World* (1939) later dramatises this burden-shifting strategy; it is not Moore's principal argument in the 1925 paper.

Is it sufficient? (reasons on both sides). - *For:* it relocates certainty to where it actually lies and shifts the **burden** onto the sceptic; later *On Certainty* offers a different hinge-based diagnosis of the strategy and thereby reframes what counts as doubt. - *Against:* Moore never *proves* he is not dreaming; against a sceptic who challenges the very **entitlement** to any truism, simply asserting ordinary knowledge **begs the question**.

Verdict. Against the *dogmatic* sceptic Moore's burden-reversal is sufficient and is deepened by the later hinge comparison; against the *radical* sceptic it is a powerful dialectical stance rather than a demonstrative refutation.

Further assessment. Moore also denies that philosophers possess a superior standpoint from which ordinary certainty must await validation. Universal scepticism conflicts with what a sceptic presupposes while asserting, remembering and communicating. Yet this is not a deductive contradiction: a radical sceptic may suspend ordinary commitments while testing their justification. Moore therefore establishes the comparative rationality of common sense more convincingly than a conclusive anti-sceptical proof.

Measured model-answer words: 378

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It presents Moore's qualified truism list, answers the sceptic's dialectical objection and distinguishes a valid proof from a complete theory of knowledge.

Exam-length guidance

Write 340–400 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

7. 2021 Q4(c) · 15 marks

Question: What does Wittgenstein mean by the statement — “Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent?” Critically discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Proposition 7 draws the **limit of language from within**: only factual, picturing propositions can be *said*; logical form, ethics, aesthetics and the mystical can at most be *shown*, so of them “one must be silent.”

Meaning in context. The Tractatus fixes the limits of sense through **bipolarity** (a genuine proposition must be able to be true *and* false). Two limiting cases carry no factual content - tautology and contradiction are **sinnlos** (senseless but well-formed); attempts to state what lies beyond the picturable world are **unsinnig** (nonsense).

What falls on the silent side. - **Logical form** - shown by propositions, never stated by them. - **Ethics and aesthetics** - transcendental; “there can be no ethical propositions.” - **The mystical** - “not *how* the world is... but *that* it is.” - **The metaphysical self** - a limit of the world, not an object in it.

Named text. Proposition 7 - Ogden: “Whereof one cannot speak, thereof one must be silent”; Pears-McGuinness: “What we cannot speak about we must pass over in silence.” Ladder (6.54): the Tractatus's own sentences are nonsense to be discarded once they have done their work.

Critical assessment. The doctrine is a precise consequence of the picture theory, not mysticism-for-its-own-sake. But it faces the **self-referential paradox**: if 7 itself cannot be said, the book saws off the branch it sits on. Readings diverge - **resolute** (plain therapeutic nonsense) vs **standard** (illuminating nonsense); Russell worried Wittgenstein says much about the unsayable.

Verdict. Proposition 7 is the disciplined terminus of the picture theory; its paradox is genuine and is best read as *marking* the boundary of sense rather than asserting a further fact beyond it.

Measured model-answer words: 265

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It reads proposition 7 through saying/showing and 6.54, adds the self-referential objection and reaches a graded verdict on elucidatory nonsense.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

8. 2022 Q1(b) · 10 marks

Question: What is Bertrand Russell's method of logical analysis? How does it ultimately end in establishing atomic theory of meaning? Discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Russell's method of **logical analysis** replaces misleading grammatical form with real logical form; pursued to its end, analysis terminates in **atomic propositions** whose meaning is their picturing of **atomic facts** - an atomic theory of meaning.

The method. Surface grammar deceives: "the present King of France" *looks* like a name but is an **incomplete symbol**. Analysis (the **theory of descriptions** is the exemplar) rewrites such sentences to expose their quantificational logical form, and **logical constructions** replace inferred entities ("substitute constructions out of known entities for inferences to unknown entities").

How it ends in atomism. Each analysis removes an apparent constituent until nothing further can be decomposed. What remains are **simples** - logically proper names for acquaintance-objects (sense-data) plus universals. Meaning bottoms out exactly here: an **atomic proposition** means the **atomic fact** it pictures (isomorphism of names/objects and arrangement/arrangement), and every molecular proposition is a **truth-function** of atomic ones.

Assessment. The acquaintance base is contestable (Sellars), but the structural claim is robust: analysis fixes meaning by grounding it in the simplest picturing propositions.

Verdict. Analysis is the method and atomism its terminus; the theory of meaning is atomic because significance is anchored in atomic propositions depicting atomic facts.

Measured model-answer words: 198

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It moves from grammatical to logical form, explains facts and atomic propositions and shows why analysis is methodological rather than physical decomposition.

Exam-length guidance

Write 150–200 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

9. 2022 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: Is there any difference between pictorial form and logical form in Ludwig Wittgenstein's picture theory of language? How does the logical form define the relation between language and reality? Explain.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Yes - **pictorial form** is what lets a picture depict *at all*, whereas **logical form** is the form shared by *every* picture and by reality; logical form is precisely the shared structure that connects language to the world.

Ontology first. "The world is the totality of facts, not of things" (1.1); states of affairs are **objects** in combination. A proposition is a **picture** of a possible situation: names go proxy for objects, and the **arrangement** of names mirrors the arrangement of objects.

Pictorial form. The possibility that the picture's elements are combined as the things are. It varies with the medium - a spatial picture has spatial form, a coloured one colour form, a musical score its own form.

Logical form. The **pictorial form common to all pictures whatever** - the form a picture and reality *must* share to be able to depict truly or falsely. A picture can depict any pictorial form, but it **cannot depict its own logical form**: logical form is **shown, not said**.

The difference. Pictorial form is the species (medium-specific); logical form is the universal genus - the minimal structure any representation must share with what it represents.

How logical form relates language and reality. A proposition connects to the world by **sharing logical form** with the fact it represents; because it pictures a mere *possibility*, it can **agree or disagree** with reality - truth or falsity, hence **bipolarity**. This picturing is **logical, not psychological**: a proposition is not a mental image.

Verdict. There is a real difference - species vs the universal genus - and it is **logical form**, the isomorphism between sentence and fact, that makes representation and therefore the whole language-world relation possible.

Measured model-answer words: 276

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It distinguishes pictorial from logical form, maps names to objects and explains why representation requires shared possibility rather than visual resemblance.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

10. 2023 Q4(b) · 15 marks

Question: Why according to Russell is the proposition — “The present king of France is bald” problematic? Critically discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The sentence is problematic because it is **meaningful yet lacks a referent**; Russell dissolves the problem by analysing the description into **existence + uniqueness + predication**, which makes the sentence **false, not meaningless**, with no dubious object.

The puzzle. Grammatically “The present King of France is bald” is subject-predicate, so it *seems* to require a King to be *about*; yet there is none. Rivals pay a price: **Meinong** posits a subsisting non-existent King (ontological extravagance); on a Fregean line the sentence lacks a truth-value.

Russell's analysis. $(\exists x)[Kx \ \& \ (\forall y)(Ky \rightarrow y=x) \ \& \ Bx]$ - "there is exactly one present King of France and he is bald." The **existence** clause is false, so the whole conjunction is **FALSE**. "The present King of France" is an **incomplete symbol**: no meaning in isolation, it *disappears* on analysis, so nothing need be denoted.

Payoff - three puzzles solved. Negative existentials ("the KoF does not exist" is coherent); **excluded middle** via **scope** (on the *secondary/narrow* occurrence "it is not the case that there is exactly one bald KoF" is **true**); identity/substitutivity (the description is quantificational, not referential).

Critical - the rival. Strawson ("On Referring," 1950): the sentence is **neither true nor false**; *using* "the present King of France" carries a **presupposition** of existence that here fails, so the question of truth-value does not arise. This is a genuine rival about *ordinary language*, but it does not overturn the *logic* of Russell's analysis, which was never a theory of conversation.

Verdict. Russell makes the sentence false and referent-free without Meinongian objects; the enduring lesson is **grammatical form $\neq$ logical form**, though Strawson's presupposition account remains a live alternative about ordinary use.

Measured model-answer words: 272

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It stages the King-of-France analysis, explains why existence failure makes the conjunction false and includes Strawson's presupposition challenge.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

11. 2024 Q1(c) · 10 marks

Question: What arguments are offered by Moore to prove that there are certain truisms, knowledge of which is a matter of common sense? Critically discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. Moore argues that a set of **truisms** is known to be true with certainty **as a matter of common sense**, and that their certainty outweighs any philosophical premise brought against them.

The arguments. 1. **The truisms themselves** ("A Defence of Common Sense," 1925): "I have a body," "the earth existed for many years," "there are other people" - each "known to be true with certainty." 2. **Knowing vs analysing:** we *know* a truism even when we cannot give its correct **analysis**; certainty does not depend on solving the paradox of analysis. 3. **Self-refutation of denial:** to assert "there are no other people" is pragmatically self-defeating, presupposing an audience and language. 4. **Burden reversal:** no premise of a sceptical argument is *more* certain than the truism it would deny.

Critical assessment. The sceptic replies that Moore **begs the question** - he relocates certainty rather than defeating radical doubt. Yet Later *On Certainty* reframes Moore: the truisms function as **hinges** on which the practice of doubt itself turns, so they are not the sort of thing that *can* be doubted.

Verdict. Moore secures the truisms **dialectically** by burden-reversal; the case is compelling against dogmatic scepticism though against scepticism it persuades rather than demonstrates.

Measured model-answer words: 200

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It reconstructs Moore's truisms and certainty comparison, then tests whether common sense supplies an argument or only an epistemic starting point.

Exam-length guidance

Write 150–200 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

12. 2024 Q3(a) · 20 marks

Question: Explain Russell’s notion of incomplete symbols. Also explain how this notion leads to the doctrine of logical atomism.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	340–400 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. An **incomplete symbol** has no meaning in isolation and *disappears* on analysis; generalising this device - descriptions, then constructions - drives analysis down to genuine simples, and that terminus is **Logical Atomism**.

Incomplete symbols defined. A symbol that means nothing on its own and contributes only in the context of a whole proposition; the **test** is that it vanishes when the sentence is rewritten. The paradigm is the **definite description** ("On Denoting," 1905): $(\exists x)[Fx \ \& \ (\forall y)(Fy \rightarrow y=x) \ \& \ Gx]$. "The present King of France is bald" is thus **false, not meaningless**, and posits no Meinongian object.

Generalisation to constructions. Classes, numbers and material objects are likewise incomplete symbols / **logical constructions**: "Wherever possible, substitute constructions out of known entities for inferences to unknown entities" (the supreme maxim; Occam's razor). A material object becomes an orderly **system of sense-data**, not an inferred hidden thing.

The road to atomism. Each analysis removes an apparent entity; the process terminates in **atomic propositions** - logically proper names for acquaintance-objects plus universals - that **picture atomic facts**. "The atoms... are logical atoms and not physical atoms." Isomorphism pairs atomic proposition with atomic fact; molecular propositions are **truth-functions**.

Assessment. The sense-datum base is vulnerable (Sellars); private data raise the **solipsism/other-minds** worry; Strawson contests the descriptions analysis; some inferences resist construction, so the maxim is a **regulative ideal**. Even so, the structural thesis - meaning and ontology bottom out in analysed simples - is exactly atomism.

Verdict. Incomplete symbols are the analytic **lever**; applied across the board they yield the sparse, structured world of logical atomism - a metaphysics generated by a method.

Why the route is not entailment. Description theory proves that an apparent grammatical subject need not be a logical constituent; it does not prove that every analysis terminates, that the residues are independent, or that they are sense-data. Atomism adds those commitments. Russell's own changing ontology confirms the distinction. The valid route is methodological: contextual definitions remove pseudo-entities, constructions reduce commitments, and the remaining constituents become candidates for atoms. It supports an atomist research programme rather than deductively demonstrating one unique inventory fully and explicitly in advance.

Measured model-answer words: 348

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It defines incomplete symbols contextually, connects descriptions and constructions to atomism and evaluates whether analysis really reaches independent simples.

Exam-length guidance

Write 340–400 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

13. 2025 Q1(d) · 10 marks

Question: "The golden mountain is very high." Discuss this statement in the context of Russell's theory of descriptions.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. "The golden mountain is very high" is handled by the **theory of descriptions**: analysed into **existence + uniqueness + predication**, its existence clause fails, so the sentence is **false** - and no golden mountain need "subsist."

The problem. The phrase denotes nothing, yet the sentence is meaningful. **Meinong** grants the golden mountain subsistence; Russell rejects that ontology.

The analysis. $(\exists x)[(Gx \ \& \ Mx) \ \& \ (\forall y)((Gy \ \& \ My) \rightarrow y=x) \ \& \ Hx]$: exactly one golden mountain exists and is very high. Since the existence clause fails, the conjunction is **false**. The description is an **incomplete symbol** that disappears on analysis, carrying no commitment to a golden mountain.

Payoff. Grammatical form differs from logical form, preserving significance without a Meinongian object.

Qualification. Russell assumes definiteness, uniqueness and a fixed scope. **Strawson** argues that ordinary use presupposes existence, so failure may produce a truth-value gap. This limits Russell's account of use, not its quantificational clarity.

Verdict. On Russell's analysis the sentence is significant but **false**; the theory dissolves the pseudo-entity, while Strawson preserves a genuine rival account of ordinary reference.

Measured model-answer words: 172

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It eliminates the golden mountain through quantificational form, avoids Meinongian commitment, keeps falsehood distinct from meaninglessness and supplies a genuine presupposition-based qualification.

Exam-length guidance

Write 150–200 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

14. 2025 Q3(c) · 15 marks

Question: "Blue is one object of sensation and green is another, and consciousness, which both sensations have in common, is different from either." Present an account of Moore's refutation of idealism with reference to this statement.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Answer the complete demand and give a qualified verdict.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	250–300 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. The quoted sentence is the crux of Moore's **Refutation of Idealism**: by distinguishing the **object** of sensation (blue, green) from the **consciousness** common to both, Moore separates what idealism runs together and so refutes *esse est percipi*.

Target. Berkeley's *esse est percipi* and, generally, idealism's claim that reality is mind-dependent.

The argument. Every sensation has two elements: the **act** (consciousness, the *same* in the sensation of blue and of green) and the **object** (the blue, the green, which *differ*). The quoted sentence states exactly this: "Blue is one object of sensation and green is another, and consciousness, which both sensations have in common, is different from either."

Diaphanous thesis. Consciousness is **transparent** - we look straight through it to the blue and overlook the act. That transparency explains *why* the idealist fuses object with act and concludes *esse est percipi*.

Result. Object $\neq$ act. Moore therefore blocks the proposed identity of *esse* with *percipi*, but non-identity alone does **not** prove that the object persists unperceived; that stronger realist conclusion needs a further argument.

Critical assessment. The **diaphanous** thesis is also the weak point: if awareness is never caught directly, the act/object distinction is *asserted* rather than *exhibited*. **Limits:** the argument refutes *one* argument for idealism, not realism directly, and does **not** touch Hegel's Absolute Idealism; the **sense-datum** legacy later collapses under Sellars.

Verdict. With reference to this statement, Moore's separation of object from act blocks the identity-based route to *esse est percipi*. An idealist may still concede a distinction within experience while denying mind-independent persistence, so Moore's strongest result is diagnostic—not a complete proof of realism.

Measured model-answer words: 267

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It uses the exact blue-green-consciousness contrast, explains diaphanous awareness and states why Moore's target is narrower than all idealism.

Exam-length guidance

Write 250–300 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

15. 2026 Q1(e) · 10 marks

Question: "I can prove now, for instance, that two human hands exist." How does Moore use this illustration to prove the existence of an external world? Critically discuss.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Explain the hands proof, state Moore's three proof conditions, and critically distinguish validity from anti-sceptical force.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	150–200 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. In *Proof of an External World* (1939), Moore raises his right hand and says "Here is one hand," then his left and says "here is another." Since hands are material objects encountered in space, at least two external objects, and therefore an external world, exist.

Moore claims the demonstration satisfies three conditions of rigorous proof. First, the premises differ from the conclusion: "here is a hand" is not identical with "an external world exists." Second, he knows the premises rather than merely believing them. Third, the conclusion follows: if two hands exist, external things exist. He need not prove every known premise before using it, because ordinary perceptual certainty exceeds the certainty of sceptical premises.

The proof reverses the burden: a sceptic must supply grounds more certain than the hands proposition. However, it does not compel the radical sceptic, who disputes Moore's claim to know the premise and charges question-begging. Later Wittgenstein's hinge analysis explains why such certainties structure

inquiry, but belongs to a later owner.

Verdict. Moore gives a valid proof if its premises are known and a powerful defence of ordinary certainty, not a neutral demonstration from premises the sceptic already accepts.

Measured model-answer words: 195

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It reconstructs the gesture and all three conditions, then separates formal validity, Moorean knowledge and dialectical persuasion.

Exam-length guidance

Write 150–200 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

16. 2026 Q4(a) · 20 marks

Question: "Wittgenstein's difficulty about not being able to say anything within a given language about the structure of that language can be met by the idea of a hierarchy of languages." Do you agree with this statement? Give reasons and justifications for your answer.

Verified metadata and demand decoding

Element	Requirement
Provenance	Exact wording and marks verified in the repository-controlled Western Philosophy PYQ ledger
Directive	Take a position, derive the difficulty from picture theory, present Russell's hierarchy, and judge its formal and transcendental reach.
Ownership	Directly owned here and counted once
Timed band	340–400 words

Timed independent model answer

Thesis. I agree only partially. A hierarchy of object-language and metalanguages solves a formal problem of self-reference and truth-definition, but it does not overcome Wittgenstein's deeper claim that logical form, as a condition of representation, cannot itself be represented.

In the *Tractatus*, a proposition pictures a possible state of affairs because its elements and their arrangement share logical form with objects and their arrangement. A picture may depict a situation, but cannot depict the pictorial form that makes depiction possible; it displays that form. Hence propositions say contingent facts, while logical form and internal relations are shown. This produces the self-application problem: the book appears to state the limits it declares unsayable, then asks the reader at 6.54 to discard its elucidatory ladder.

Russell's 1922 Introduction proposes a hierarchy. Language L1 cannot state its own structure; a metalanguage L2 can describe L1; L3 can describe L2, and so on without a final language. The proposal is technically fruitful. Later, Tarski independently showed why truth for a formalised object-language requires an essentially richer metalanguage.

The hierarchy succeeds where the difficulty is local: it separates use from mention, blocks crude semantic self-reference and permits rigorous syntax or truth-definitions for L1. Yet it fails as a complete answer. L2 has a form it cannot internally characterise, so the limit is displaced upward. An open hierarchy supplies no final standpoint from which the totality of language can be described. More importantly, Wittgenstein's claim concerns representation as such, not missing vocabulary within one language. Ethics, aesthetics, the metaphysical subject and the mystical are not facts made sayable by a higher syntax.

The interpretive qualification matters. On the traditional reading, the hierarchy captures some structural claims but not ineffable value or form. On the resolute reading, it answers the wrong question because the *Tractatus* offers therapy, not higher-order doctrines. Later Wittgenstein abandons a single logical form rather than ascending levels.

Verdict. The hierarchy is a genuine formal-semantic solution but a transcendental evasion: it converts one unsayable limit into an indefinite series of further unresolved limits.

Measured model-answer words: 340

Qualification / criticism: The model includes an explicit limit, objection, rival or interpretive qualification; reproduce it rather than ending with exposition.

Why this structure earns marks: It distinguishes Russell's formal proposal from Wittgenstein's transcendental claim, uses Tarski only as later corroboration, and reaches a reasoned partial-agreement verdict.

Exam-length guidance

Write 340–400 words. Open with the controlling claim, reconstruct the argument in named steps, attach the canonical example or text, add the strongest qualification, and end with a graded verdict.

Original transfer drills

These are original learner-practice questions, not PYQs or official answer keys.

Original 1 · 10 marks

Question: Explain why Moore's three conditions may establish a proof without satisfying the radical sceptic.

Demand decoding: Reconstruct the 1939 proof, distinguish validity from dialectical force, and end with a qualified judgement.

Timed model answer

Introduction. In *Proof of an External World* (1939), Moore raises one hand and then the other: if these hands exist, at least two external objects exist. The demonstration can satisfy Moore's standards of proof while leaving the radical sceptic unmoved.

Organised body. Moore requires that the premise differ from the conclusion, that the premise be known, and that the conclusion follow from it. "Here is a hand" differs from "an external world exists"; Moore claims perceptual knowledge of the premise; and the inference is valid because a hand is an external object. He also refuses an infinite demand to prove every premise before it may support another conclusion.

Criticism / qualification. The dispute concerns the second condition. A radical sceptic invokes dreaming or deception precisely to deny that Moore knows the premise. Reasserting ordinary knowledge therefore reverses the burden but does not derive it from sceptic-neutral grounds.

Conclusion. Moore supplies a valid proof conditional on ordinary perceptual knowledge and a powerful defence of common sense, not a demonstration that compels someone who suspends that knowledge.

Measured model-answer words: 174

Why this earns marks: It states all three conditions, identifies the disputed premise and gives a bounded verdict instead of calling the proof simply successful or circular.

Word/time guidance: 150–200 words in about 12 minutes; spend roughly 35 words on the proof, 75 on the conditions, 45 on the sceptical challenge and 20 on the verdict.

Original 2 · 15 marks

Question: Compare Russell's logical atomism with the *Tractatus* account of objects, elementary propositions and logical independence.

Demand decoding: Establish the shared atomist architecture, compare the status of simples and propositions, identify the decisive differences, and qualify both projects.

Timed model answer

Introduction. Russell and the early Wittgenstein share an atomist ambition: analyse complex discourse into simple propositions whose structure corresponds to simple worldly combinations. Yet Russell's version remains epistemologically grounded, while the *Tractatus* presents a transcendental account of what determinate sense requires.

Organised body. 1. **Objects and atoms.** Russell's "logical atoms" are the final residues of analysis—phase-specific particulars or sense-data together with universals, approached through acquaintance. Wittgenstein postulates simple **objects** without identifying their empirical nature; they are characterised by their possibilities of combination. 2. **Facts and propositions.** For Russell, an atomic proposition contains names and a predicate or relation and is true when an atomic fact has the corresponding arrangement. For Wittgenstein, an elementary proposition is a configuration of names picturing a possible state of affairs through shared logical form. 3. **Complexity.** Both treat molecular propositions as truth-functions rather than as names of additional complex objects. Wittgenstein radicalises this through the general form and the generalised joint-negation operation N. 4. **Independence.** Russell uses logical

independence as an analytic aspiration but accepts controversial negative facts. The *Tractatus* strictly requires elementary propositions to be mutually independent and rejects logical constants as representatives.

Criticism / qualification. Russell's acquaintance base risks privacy and instability; Wittgenstein never supplies an uncontested elementary proposition, while colour exclusion pressures strict independence. Russell also admits controversial negative facts, whereas Wittgenstein treats negation as an operation rather than a further worldly constituent.

Conclusion. The programmes share structural atomism, but differ in epistemic grounding, specification of simples and the rigor with which logical independence governs the system.

Measured model-answer words: 255

Why this earns marks: It compares by common criteria rather than giving parallel summaries, uses exact technical vocabulary and closes with one criticism of each version.

Word/time guidance: 250–300 words in about 18 minutes; use four comparison axes and reserve the final quarter for qualification and judgement.

Original 3 · 20 marks

Question: Does logical analysis eliminate metaphysics or reconstruct it? Discuss through Moore, Russell and the early Wittgenstein.

Demand decoding: Define the two possible functions of analysis, compare all three thinkers, test the elimination thesis against their positive commitments, and reach a graded conclusion.

Timed model answer

Introduction. Logical analysis is often presented as an anti-metaphysical solvent, but in Moore, Russell and the early Wittgenstein it performs a double task. It eliminates claims generated by confusion while reconstructing a disciplined account of reality, knowledge or representation.

Organised body.

Moore—correction without abolition. Moore analyses idealist claims such as *esse est percipi* by distinguishing awareness from its object. This blocks an identity-based route to idealism, but it does not by itself prove unperceived persistence. His defence of common sense similarly makes philosophical theory answer to known truisms. Analysis therefore removes overclaim while retaining a modest realist orientation.

Russell—elimination that yields ontology. The theory of descriptions eliminates apparent entities: “the F is G” becomes existence, uniqueness and predication, so an empty description need not denote a subsisting object. Logical constructions extend this economy by replacing inferences to unknown entities with structures built from known ones. Yet analysis is not metaphysically neutral. It seeks a terminus in logically proper names, universals and atomic facts; elimination therefore reconstructs the sparse ontology of logical atomism.

Early Wittgenstein—delimitation from within. The *Tractatus* eliminates traditional metaphysical sentences as *unsinnig* when they try to picture no possible fact. Every senseful proposition is generated truth-functionally from elementary propositions; logical form is shown, not said. Nevertheless, objects, states of affairs and logical space state the conditions that any representation must satisfy. The book thus appears to advance a transcendental framework while declaring its own elucidations disposable at 6.54.

Comparison. The three projects therefore move at different levels: Moore tests philosophical claims against what is better known, Russell rewrites propositions to expose ontological commitments, and Wittgenstein marks the formal boundary within which any factual claim can count as senseful.

Criticism / qualification. Moore's analysis underdetermines realism; Russell's final atoms and sense-data base remain contestable; Wittgenstein's ladder creates a self-application problem. Strawson also shows that successful formal elimination need not capture ordinary linguistic use.

Conclusion. Logical analysis neither simply abolishes nor simply preserves metaphysics. It eliminates inflated entities and pseudo-propositions, then reconstructs thinner commitments: Moorean epistemic realism, Russellian atomism and Tractarian conditions of representation. Its achievement is therefore revisionary metaphysics disciplined by analysis, not metaphysical neutrality.

Measured model-answer words: 359

Why this earns marks: It uses one controlling issue across all three thinkers, distinguishes negative and constructive uses of analysis, includes specific limits and gives a genuinely graded verdict.

Word/time guidance: 340–400 words in about 24 minutes; allot one compact paragraph to each thinker, one comparative criticism paragraph and a two-sentence conclusion.

Final answer checklist

- Attribute the doctrine and named text precisely.
- Use exact quantificational structure where descriptions are asked.
- Distinguish Russell's atoms from Wittgenstein's objects.
- Keep *sinnlos* apart from *unsinnig*.
- Do not attribute Russell's hierarchy, Tarski's later semantics or verificationism to Wittgenstein.
- End critical questions with a bounded verdict, not a summary.